

Before I begin: this speech contains brief mentions of suicide and murder. Please take care of yourself.

I was asked to write a speech on resistance. And I looked within myself. Where am I resisted? Where in my body do I feel resistance, pressure, tightness? Where am I reacting to resistance? Where am I pulling my resistance from?

I lay all of this down. And I sit with each question, quietly.

Resistance is older than any of our flags. It predates the ones we wave, and the ones we were born under. And that is where I want to begin.

I have to admit, this request to speak at this event was met with a lot of resistance from me. Ironically. At an event centred around pride, it felt that stepping into a place of celebration meant leaving a lot of people behind me. I was born and raised in Morocco. I had already left my people when I uprooted my life to come here. And so stepping away from them again to be part of a celebration they don't get to share felt alienating to me, and unfair to them.

But today I thought of bringing them with me. Speaking their names. Bringing their words with me. You will hear them today alongside mine. I wanted as many women of colour's voices present as possible. When asked to speak, I find it deeply important to bring others with you, in the intention and in the execution.

Context must always be declared. Because for many of the people I am about to name, inequality and vulnerability are a constant. They have always survived, in conditions many of us standing here will never fully comprehend. And that survival is the form their resistance took. Not marches. Not flags. Survival.

So today I want to name some people who were never centred. I want to say their names out loud, which is something the world did not always do for them.

I want to say the name of Eden Knight. A Saudi trans woman, twenty-three years old, who had built a life in the United States. Her family hired people to bring her back to Saudi Arabia. Her passport was taken. Her hormones were taken. She was forced to detransition. Before she died she wrote: "I hope that the world gets better for us. I hope our people get old. I hope we get to see our kids grow up to fight for us."

I want to say the name of Hajar Al-Asami. A Kuwaiti transmasculine person, killed by their own brother in 2019. The brother received a lenient sentence. There is no long article about Hajar. No hashtag campaign. Just a name, a brother, a lenient sentence.

I want to say the name of Abdellah Taia. One of the few Moroccan writers openly out. He is ours to claim.

I want to say the name of Frank Ocean. A Black American musician who built his queer love into the walls of his music before he ever said a word about it publicly.

I name all of them together. The ones we lost and the ones still making their way.

No one leaves home unless home is the mouth of a shark. I have been carrying the old anthem in my mouth for so long that there is no space for another song, another tongue, another language. I know a shame that shrouds, totally engulfs. I tore up and ate my own passport in an airport hotel. I am bloated with language I cannot afford to forget.

Warsan Shire, "Home"

By the time I left Morocco I had felt like I had escaped the bite of a shark. I arrived a few weeks before the pandemic hit. I arrived by plane with a visa in my passport. Not everyone who arrives here arrives this way.

Some people arrive after years inside an asylum process that has no end in sight. Some arrive without a single person in this country who knows their name. Some arrive not speaking any of the local languages and must navigate systems that were not built for them, in languages that are not theirs, facing frontline workers who lie, who hide information, who minimize what they went through just to get here. Some arrive and spend their nights moving from park to park because there is nowhere else to go. Some arrive as queer people fleeing persecution and then have to prove that persecution to institutions that do not understand or believe them.

And from inside a locked apartment in a new continent, I thought about my mother. Who had made it a habit to wake up at sunrise to mention me and my legal situation in her morning prayer. I could not go back to see her if something happened. In the meantime I grieved her while she was still alive. I grieved my family while they were still there. That grief, over time, became anger. Anger that seeped through my skin into my veins, circulating in my bloodstream, attacking different organs at random. Grief that had not found its words yet.

And because resistance is not only grief, I also want to say what we got. What happened. What we made and what found us.

Yellowjackets. A show about women surviving in the wilderness, eating each other alive, and loving each other through it.

Kelela's Raven Album: An Ethiopian-American queer artist who came back after six years of silence with an album she said she made to service the people who have always been in the front row : queer Black people.

Amaarae, a Ghanaian-American queer artist making afropop that is joyful and completely uncontainable.

And I want to say plainly: most of what gets made is still very white. We celebrate what we get. And we keep asking for more.

We all carry privilege. Every single person in this crowd. And I know that word can make people uncomfortable. But privilege is a compass. It leads you towards the other.

I am a cis woman. I am able-bodied. I had access to education. I arrived here with a visa and French already in my mouth. My compass points towards the ones who did not.

Our responsibility is to carry each other. But I want to be precise about what I mean by each other. Each other is not another me. It is not someone I can easily link myself to, someone I can recognise, someone I can swiftly project my own experience into. Each other is the person who is most different from me. The person whose struggle I do not immediately understand. The person who is more vulnerable than me in this specific moment, because the same way we have been alienated, we all have places where we are not.

What I had the most trouble with, when I arrived in Europe, was the hesitancy I felt others carried when it came to going towards people. I come from a culture that does not have that pause.

So now I want to speak to this crowd directly, on behalf of the people who are not here.

Come to us. Come to the queer migrants stuck inside asylum processes that stretch on for years with no answer. Go to the ones sitting in hostile and cold reception centres that were never designed to hold a human being with dignity. Go to the ones who do not believe they are allowed to take up any space in this world, who have been told so many times in so many ways that this space was not made for them. Go to the ones who are not in this crowd today because no one thought to reach out and make sure they knew they were welcome.

Come to us. Do not wait to be found.

Going towards the other does not always look dramatic. Sometimes it looks like a text message. Sometimes it looks like listening. Sometimes it looks like organising something and asking, from the very beginning, who is not in this room and why.

Same way we were pushed to the edges, we must now push ourselves towards the edges. Towards the people standing furthest from the centre of this crowd. Towards the queer migrants who came here with everything they had packed in a suitcase. Towards the voices who are still being told their queerness is a Western import, a corruption, a shame, when in fact their resistance is older than any of our flags.

And I find my resistance in every name I said today. In Eden. In Hajar. In Kelela. In Frank. In my mother. In all the people who survived things they should not have had to survive, and still showed up, and still loved, and still made things beautiful.

That is where resistance lives. In the carrying. In the going towards.

So do not wait to be asked. Watch. Listen. And offer. That is two gifts, instead of the half gift of asking.